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Learning Space

NEWSPAPER 27th November, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

48th WEEK



ROHINGYAS & CHINA PLAN

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II... INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBORHOOD- RELATIONS.



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LIVE



NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

27th NOVEMBER, 2017

The China plan

The devil will be in the detail of the Myanmar-Bangladesh deal on Rohingya repatriation

The agreement reached between Myanmar and Bangladesh to repatriate Rohingya refugees suggests that the Chinese proposal has found some traction as a solution to the crisis. It has been sealed after a three-month military operation by Myanmar in Rakhine, which resulted in around 600,000 Rohingya fleeing the province to Bangladesh, leading to a humanitarian crisis and a war of words between Dhaka and Naypyidaw. It is against this background that China stepped in with its three-point plan. Earlier this month, Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi travelled to Bangladesh and Myanmar with the proposal; Beijing later claimed both countries had accepted it. Under the plan, Myanmar and Bangladesh were to hold bilateral talks and reach a repatriation agreement - which has been achieved. However, the first step in Beijing's approach - which involved a declaration of ceasefire in Rakhine to halt further displacement and bringing immediate relief to the state's devastated Rohingya - has not taken effect. If this were to happen, the third part of the proposal will presumably take effect, with China providing economic assistance for the development of the Rakhine region as part of a long-term solution.

China, which has historically been wary of stepping into domestic conflicts in other countries, is being proactive in this case. Its own interest is at stake. Beijing enjoys good relations with both Bangladesh and Myanmar; also, Rakhine is an important link in its Belt and Road Initiative. China is building a \$7.3 billion deep-water port in the province and has invested \$2.45 billion to build an oil and gas pipeline connecting coastal Rakhine to Yunnan. China has put pressure on Myanmar because a protracted conflict in Rakhine will be decidedly against Beijing's economic interests. The signing of a repatriation deal suggests this pressure tactic is working. But details of the agreement, including the number of Rohingya who will be sent back, and the timeline, have not been revealed. It is also not clear whether the refugees themselves want to go back to a place they had fled in such perilous circumstances. Or in the event they do, where they will be resettled. From the details of the plan it is clear that China sees the Rohingya crisis as an economic problem, given that its solution is centred on development. While economic assistance is essential, the real problem is arguably deeply political, and there needs to be an accompanying political solution. Any proposal can only make limited headway unless Myanmar is willing to roll back the institutional barriers that render Rohingya second-class people. Unless they are accepted as equal citizens, there is unlikely to be a long-term solution to the Rakhine unrest.

Date :25th November, 2017

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THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

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IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY / MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Examine various aspects of Rohingya problem. Is the Chinese 3 pronged solution is viable? Discuss

FACTUAL INFORMATION



- 1 Rohingyas belong to Muslim sect.
- 2 They are one of Myanmar's many ethnic minorities.
- 3 Rohingyas say that they are descendants of Arab traders who have been in the region for generations.
- 4 Myanmar Government sees them as illegal immigrants from Bangladesh.
- 5 The Country also denies them the citizenship as per the Citizenship Law 1982.
- 6 Myanmar is predominantly Buddhist country.
- 7 It has a long history of communal mistrust.
- 8 The country was under the Military rule for several years and this mistrust is exploited by the army.

INDIA

NEPAL

BANGLADESH

Myanmar
(Burma)

VIETNAM

Lao PDR

Rakhine

THAILAND

CAMBODIA

Bay of Bengal

Gulf



WHAT IS THE ORIGIN OF CLASHES?



- 1 Militants suspected to be from the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army attacked military and police outposts.
- 2 The military crackdown that followed has been widely condemned as disproportionate.
- 3 The Govt. is accused of being the on-looker.

NEWS REPORT



- Bangladesh and Myanmar have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on the return of Rohingya people, who fled the Rakhine state.
- At least 6,00,000 Rohingya people have fled Myanmar to neighbouring Bangladesh.
- They fled subsequent to the operation by the army after attack by Rohingya militants.
- The repatriation process is expected to start within the next two months.



CHINA AND THREE-POINT PLAN

- 1 Myanmar and Bangladesh have to hold bilateral talks and reach a repatriation agreement.
- 2 Declaration of ceasefire in Rakhine to halt further displacement and bringing immediate relief to the state's devastated Rohingyas.
- 3 China to provide economic assistance for the development of the Rakhine region.



WHAT ABOUT THE DETAILS OF THE AGREEMENT?

- 1 No details were revealed. The number of Rohingyas who will be sent back and the time-frame are not clear.
- 2 It is also not clear, whether the refugees themselves want to go back to a place they had fled in such perilous circumstances.
- 3 It is also a debatable point, where they will be settled.
- 4 Their houses have been dismantled by the army.

WHY CHINA INTERFERED?

- 1** China sees this as an economic problem. It's solution is centered on development.
- 2** Normally, China do not step into domestic conflicts of other countries, but it is proactive in this case. The reason is, it's own interest is at stake.
- 3** Rakhine is important link in the Belt and Road Initiative.
- 4** China is building \$ 7.3 billion deep-water port in the province and it has invested \$ 2.45 billion to build an oil and gas pipeline connecting coastal Rakhine to Yunnan region of China.

- 5** China put the pressure on Myanmar as the protracted conflict in Rakhine will go against Beijing's economic interests.





CHINA

East China Sea

NEPAL

INDIA

BANGLADESH

MYANMAR
(BURMA)

Lao PDR

THAILAND

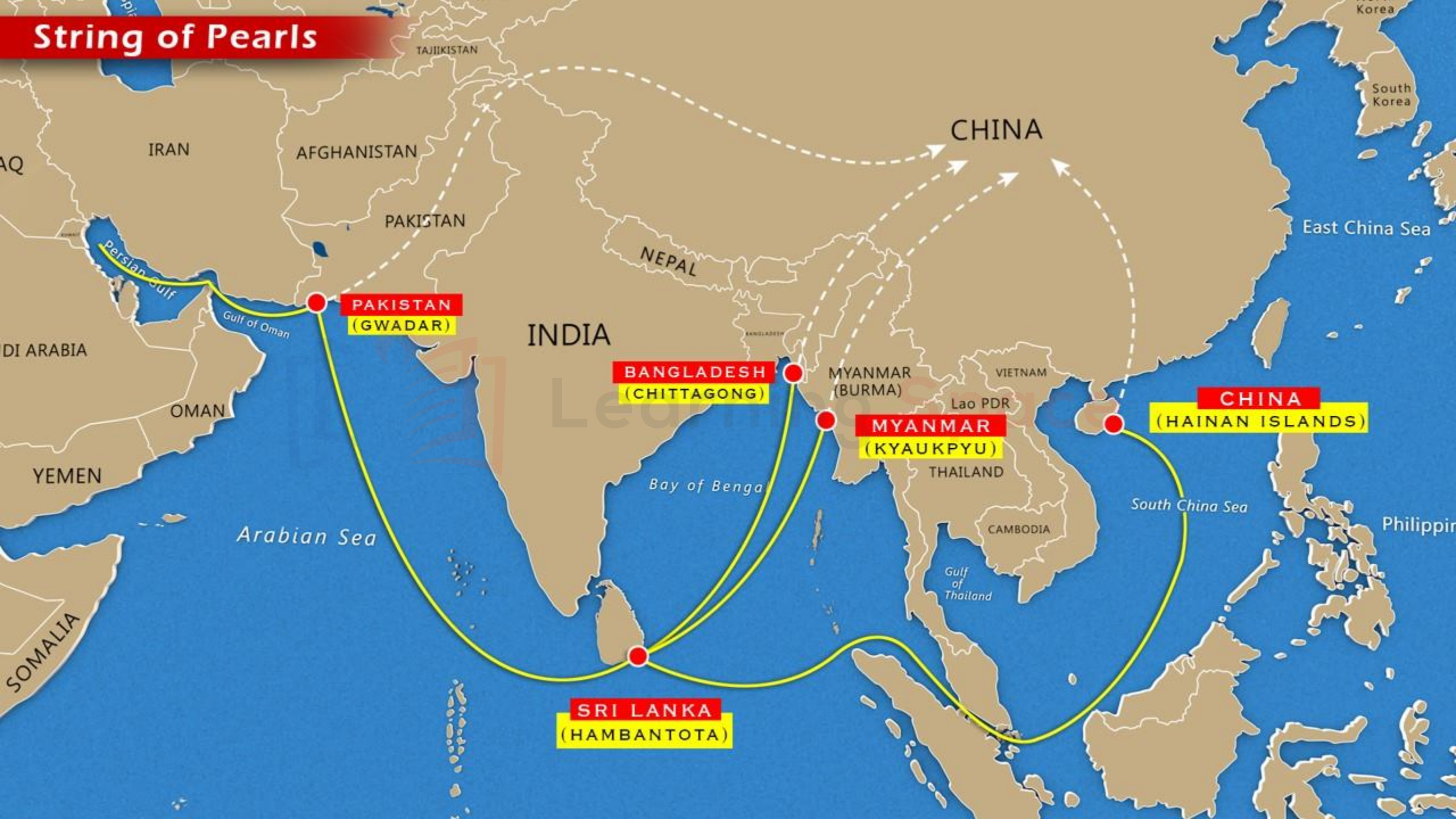
KYAUKPYU PORT

Bay of Bengal

South China Sea

Gulf of Thailand

String of Pearls





BUT THE REAL ISSUE IS POLITICAL

- 1 The real issue is political.
- 2 The Myanmar must roll-back the institutional barriers that render Rohingyas as second-class people.
- 3 They must be accepted as equal citizens.

For China's plan to be successful, Myanmar should treat the problem as political and give equal status to the Rohingyas, so as to merge them in the main stream

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